Moshe in His Brother's Cloud: The Guest of the Fourth Night and the Humility of the Sukkah

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On the night of Monday, 28 September 2026, the fourth night of Sukkot 5787, Moshe entered the sukkah as the leading guest. In the order of the Zohar, he follows Avraham, Yitzchak and Yaakov, and on the fifth night, Tuesday, 29 September 2026, he gives way to Aharon.

It is a strange thing, when you think about it, to welcome Moshe into a sukkah.

Whose merit was the cloud?

The Talmud records two views of what the booths of the wilderness were. Rabbi Akiva says they were actual booths. Rabbi Eliezer says they were the clouds of glory that surrounded the people (Sukkah 11b). Many teach the sukkah in the light of Rabbi Eliezer's view: the schach above us recalls the cloud that sheltered Israel for forty years.

And the cloud itself? The Talmud connects it to one of Moshe's siblings. Three good providers arose for Israel when they left Egypt: Moshe, Aharon and Miriam. Three gifts came through them: the well, the pillar of cloud, and the manna. The well came in the merit of Miriam, the pillar of cloud in the merit of Aharon, and the manna in the merit of Moshe (Taanit 9a).

So when Moshe sits in the sukkah, he sits under a shelter that recalls a cloud the Talmud credits to his brother's merit, not his own. The greatest prophet, the one who spoke with G-d face to face (Devarim 34:10), is a guest in the house of Aharon's cloud.

The humblest of men

The Torah gives Moshe one description above all others: "And the man Moshe was very humble, more than any person on the face of the earth" (Bamidbar 12:3). The verse comes, of all places, right after Miriam and Aharon speak against him. Moshe does not answer. He does not defend himself.

A humble man can sit comfortably under his brother's roof. He does not need the shelter to bear his name. He is glad that the people are covered, and he does not ask by whose merit.

That may be the first thing Moshe teaches as a guest. The sukkah is not a monument to anyone's achievement. It is a shelter made of many merits, most of them not our own: our parents' and grandparents' faithfulness, the kindness of teachers, the sacrifices of people we will never meet. We sit under all of it.

The tent outside the camp

There is another tent in Moshe's story. After the sin of the golden calf, "Moshe would take the tent and pitch it outside the camp, far from the camp, and he called it the Tent of Meeting; and anyone who sought G-d would go out to the Tent of Meeting, which was outside the camp" (Shemot 33:7).

That tent was open. Anyone who sought G-d could come. Moshe's tent was not a private study. It was a place where seekers found a door.

The sukkah is like that. It sits outside the house, on the balcony or in the yard, in the open. It is the least private room we have all year. Anyone passing can see in. On these days of Chol HaMoed, when the door of the sukkah is literally open, the question Moshe's tent asks is simple: who is seeking, and have we made room for them?

The one who did not enter

Moshe led the people through the whole wilderness, through all forty years of booths and clouds, and did not enter the land. We sit in our sukkot in the land he saw only from Mount Nevo. He is our guest in a place he longed for and never reached.

That, too, is part of the humility of the sukkah. We are not the builders of everything we enjoy. Others led us here. Some of them never saw it. When we welcomed Moshe on the fourth night, we welcomed the one who carried the people to the edge of what we now take for granted, and we remembered to be grateful.

On the fifth night Aharon, whose merit brought the cloud, takes his place at the head of the table. Moshe, as always, is glad to make room.

For the table

1. The Talmud says the pillar of cloud came in Aharon's merit, the manna in Moshe's.
2. So Moshe sits under a shelter that recalls his brother's merit.
3. The Torah calls Moshe the humblest person on earth.

Sources

- Sukkah 11b (Rabbi Eliezer and Rabbi Akiva on the booths of the wilderness)
- Taanit 9a (the well, the pillar of cloud and the manna in the merit of Miriam, Aharon and Moshe)
- Bamidbar 12:3 ("the man Moshe was very humble")
- Shemot 33:7 (the tent outside the camp)
- Devarim 34:10 ("whom G-d knew face to face")
- Zohar, Emor 103a–104a (the *ushpizin*)

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